

The ARVN

Frequently maligned as the puppet army of foreign powers, and often the victim of its own leaders and patrons, the Army of the Republic of Vietnam (ARVN) became a scapegoat for South Vietnam's defeat by the North Vietnamese.

◀◀ BEFORE

The French created a Vietnamese National Army (VNA) of four divisions in 1949 to fight with them against the Viet Minh.

THE VNA

The officers and NCOs of the VNA were almost entirely French, and the soldiers themselves remained **poorly trained and ill equipped**. Their weapons and transportation were outmoded and in poor condition.

DIEM'S ARMY

President Diem, South Vietnam's first president, transformed the VNA into the ARVN. Its main role from its foundation was to continue the fight against **communist insurgency** from the North.

The ARVN was formally established by the government of President Diem in 1955, following the French withdrawal. The US then took over supplying and training the force. In spite of US support, morale remained low.

Organization

The ARVN grew from a modest strength of 150,000 in the 1950s to a seemingly robust total of one million by 1975. In addition to the army, there were separately organized and smaller air, naval, marine, and commando services. The ARVN was organized on three levels: regular forces, regional forces (RF), and popular forces (PF). American soldiers often referred to the last two of these as "Ruff Puffs." Equipment and training varied widely at the three levels. The best was the regular army, consisting of 13 infantry divisions, seven ranger groups, and various elite and support elements. The regional forces supplied the troops for the ARVN's four regional commands, and the popular forces under the control of local councils provided security for cities, towns, and major installations.